



Developing Specific Norms

From vague values to commitments you can see and measure

A norm you can't observe is a norm you can't keep. Vague values — “be respectful,” “show up on time” — sound good, but no one can tell whether the team is actually living them. A specific commitment names the behavior, so anyone in the room can see whether it's happening. Turn each norm your team cares about into a commitment you can see and measure.

1 · Vague value → specific commitment

Vague value	Specific, observable commitment
“Be respectful”	One person speaks at a time. We don't interrupt or hold side conversations.
“Show up on time”	We're seated and ready at the start time. If we'll be late or absent, we tell the team by that morning.
“Come prepared”	Every member brings scored common-assessment data, broken out by learning target, to each data meeting.
“Be positive and open-minded”	We give every proposal a full hearing and respond with “yes, and...” before “no, but...”
“Stay focused”	The agenda stays visible, and the timekeeper redirects off-topic talk within two minutes.
“Share the work”	Roles rotate on a schedule, and everyone takes a turn.

Notice the pattern: each specific version names an observable behavior, and several add a number or a trigger you could actually check.

2 · The specificity check

Before you keep a proposed norm, make it pass all four. If it fails any, sharpen it.

- ☐ **Behavior, not value** — Does it name something people DO — not a feeling or attitude?
- ☐ **Observable** — Could a visitor tell, just by watching, whether we kept it?
- ☐ **Measurable** — Can we count it, rate it, or clearly judge it yes / no?
- ☐ **Owned** — Is it written as “We will...” — a commitment we all agreed to?

3 · “Looks like / sounds like” builder

For each norm you're considering, describe what it would look like and sound like in the room. If you can't fill both columns, the norm is still too vague — sharpen it before it goes on the list.

Proposed norm	Looks like (what we'd see)	Sounds like (what we'd hear)

4 • Draft your team's norms

Write your team's 4–6 final norms as specific “We will...” commitments.

1. We will _____
2. We will _____
3. We will _____
4. We will _____
5. We will _____
6. We will _____

5 • Make it measurable

Your norms only matter if you check them. Decide how you'll know you're keeping them — for example, a quick thumbs check against your norms at the end of a meeting, or a norm your timekeeper watches for.

How we'll check we're keeping our norms: _____

Where we keep this worksheet (team's shared cycle folder): _____

Bigger picture: the Collaborative Team Rubric gives a broader read on how your team is functioning overall — it's a companion to these norms, not a grade on them. You'll take that baseline at Meeting 3 and re-score it across the year to watch your team grow.

Leave with → your next step

You've written norms your team can see and measure. Carry them into Worksheet 3: Holding Each Other Accountable — where you'll agree how you'll hold each other to them and practice the conversation when one slips.